

Migrating from MkDocs

This guide walks you through migrating an existing [MkDocs](#) project to DocsForge. Whether you're using MkDocs with the Material theme or a custom setup, the migration is straightforward and brings significant benefits.

Why Migrate?

Bundled Dependencies

DocsForge ships with all dependencies pre-bundled. You don't need to manage:

- `mkdocs-material` (and its 20+ dependencies)
- Python environment for MkDocs
- Node.js for build tooling
- KaTeX, Mermaid, or other JS libraries



Zero Installation

Just install the `docsforge` CLI tool and you're ready to build. No `pip install`, no `npm install`, no dependency conflicts.

Zero Configuration

DocsForge works out of the box with sensible defaults. Many projects need **no configuration file at all** — just run `docsforge build` in a directory with Markdown files.

When you do need configuration, `docsforge.yml` is simpler and more focused than `mkdocs.yml`.

Same Theme Quality

DocsForge uses the same visual foundation as MkDocs Material (the most popular MkDocs theme). You get:

- Responsive design
- Dark/light mode toggle

- Navigation sidebar and search
- Code syntax highlighting
- Admonitions (callout boxes)
- Tables of contents



Material Theme Built-In

The Material theme is built into DocsForge. No separate installation or theme declaration needed.

Migration Command

Manual Migration

DocsForge does not yet provide an automatic migration command. Convert your project manually by following the steps below. The rest of this guide covers each aspect in detail.



Backup First

Always commit your current state to version control before migrating:

```
git add -A
git commit -m "backup before docsforge migration"
```

Configuration File Changes

File Rename

The simplest change: rename your configuration file:

```
mv mkdocs.yml docsforge.yml
```

Key Differences

Feature	MkDocs (<code>mkdocs.yml</code>)	DocsForge (<code>docsforge.yml</code>)
Theme declaration	<code>theme: name: material</code>	Not needed — built-in
Theme customization	<code>theme: palette, features,</code> etc.	Top-level keys like <code>palette,</code> <code>features</code>
Extra CSS/JS	<code>extra_css: ,</code> <code>extra_javascript:</code>	Remove — assets are vendored
Plugins	<code>plugins: list</code>	Remove built-ins — keep only custom ones
Markdown extensions	<code>markdown_extensions: list</code>	Remove built-ins — keep only custom ones
Extra variables	<code>extra:</code>	<code>extra:</code> (same syntax)
Site metadata	<code>site_name, site_url,</code> <code>site_description</code>	Same keys, same meaning

Example: Minimal Config

MkDocs (`mkdocs.yml`):

```

site_name: My Documentation
site_url: https://example.com/docs

theme:
  name: material
  palette:
    - scheme: default
      primary: indigo
      accent: indigo
      toggle:
        icon: material/brightness-7
        name: Switch to dark mode
    - scheme: slate
      primary: indigo
      accent: indigo
      toggle:
        icon: material/brightness-4
        name: Switch to light mode

plugins:
  - search
  - minify

```

```

- with-pdf

markdown_extensions:
- admonition
- pymdownx.details
- pymdownx.superfences
- pymdownx.highlight:
    anchor_linenums: true
- pymdownx.inlinehilite
- pymdownx.snippets
- pymdownx.tabbed:
    alternate_style: true
- pymdownx.arithmatex:
    generic: true

extra_javascript:
- javascripts/mathjax.js
- https://polyfill.io/v3/polyfill.min.js?features=es6
- https://cdn.jsdelivr.net/npm/mathjax@3/es5/tex-mml-autoload.js

extra_css:
- stylesheets/extra.css

```

DocsForge (docsforge.yml):

```

site_name: My Documentation
site_url: https://example.com/docs

# Theme is built-in - use "theme: name: material"
theme:
  name: material
  palette:
    - scheme: default
      primary: indigo
      accent: indigo
      toggle:
        icon: material/brightness-7
        name: Switch to dark mode
    - scheme: slate
      primary: indigo
      accent: indigo
      toggle:
        icon: material/brightness-4
        name: Switch to light mode

# No plugins section needed for built-ins
# Add only custom plugins here:
# plugins:
#   - your-custom-plugin

# No markdown_extensions section needed for built-ins
# Add only custom extensions here:
# markdown_extensions:
#   - my_custom_extension

# Remove extra_javascript and extra_css for vendored assets

```

```
# Keep only your truly custom styles:
# extra_css:
#   - stylesheets/extra.css
```

Simpler is Better

Start with no config file at all. Run `docsforge build` and see what works. Add configuration only for things that need customization.

Plugin Migration

Built-In Plugins (Remove from Config)

These MkDocs plugins are **built into DocsForge** and should be removed from your configuration:

MkDocs Plugin	DocsForge Status	Notes
<code>search</code>	✓ Built-in	Full-text search with no config needed
<code>minify</code>	✓ Built-in	HTML/CSS/JS minification always enabled in production
<code>offline</code>	✓ Built-in	Service worker generated automatically
<code>tags</code>	✓ Built-in	Tag support enabled by default
<code>blog</code>	✓ Built-in	Blog plugin available
<code>social</code>	✗ Not built-in	Requires Pillow + CairoSVG; use custom images if needed
<code>i18n</code>	✗ Not built-in	Multi-language support not yet available

Plugins to Remove from `mkdocs.yml`

```
# REMOVE these from your mkdocs.yml before migration:
plugins:
  - search          # Built-in
```

```
- minify          # Built-in
- tags           # Built-in
# Keep only non-built-in plugins:
# - with-pdf
# - your-custom-plugin
```

Custom Plugins

If you use custom MkDocs plugins, check if DocsForge has a native equivalent:

Custom Plugin	DocsForge Alternative
<code>mkdocs-with-pdf</code>	Not available; use an external PDF generator
<code>mkdocs-exclude</code>	Use <code>exclude_docs:</code> in <code>docsforge.yml</code>
<code>mkdocs-redirects</code>	Not built-in; requires a custom plugin
<code>mkdocs-git-revision-date</code>	Git dates are populated automatically in templates

Plugin Compatibility

MkDocs plugins are **not compatible** with DocsForge. Custom plugins must be rewritten using the DocsForge plugin API. Contact the plugin author or check the DocsForge plugin registry for alternatives.

Extension Migration

Built-In Extensions (Remove from Config)

These Markdown extensions are **enabled by default** in DocsForge:

Extension	MkDocs Name	DocsForge Status
Admonitions	<code>admonition</code>	✓ Built-in
Code fences	<code>codehilite</code> or <code>pymdownx.highlight</code>	✓ Built-in (with line numbers)

Extension	MkDocs Name	DocsForge Status
Inline code highlighting	<code>pymdownx.inlinehilite</code>	✓ Built-in
Tables	<code>tables</code>	✓ Built-in
Meta blocks	<code>meta</code>	✓ Built-in
Table of contents	<code>toc</code>	✓ Built-in (with permalink support)
Details/summary	<code>pymdownx.details</code>	✓ Built-in
Superfences	<code>pymdownx.superfences</code>	✓ Built-in
Task lists	<code>pymdownx.tasklist</code>	✓ Built-in
Snippets	<code>pymdownx.snippets</code>	✓ Built-in
Tabbed content	<code>pymdownx.tabbed</code>	✓ Built-in
Emoji	<code>pymdownx.emoji</code>	✓ Built-in (with Material icon set)
Arithmatex	<code>pymdownx.arithmatex</code>	✓ Built-in (using KaTeX)
Mermaid diagrams	<code>pymdownx.superfences</code> + custom fence	✓ Built-in (Mermaid supported)
Keys	<code>pymdownx.keys</code>	✓ Built-in
Mark	<code>pymdownx.mark</code>	✓ Built-in
Critic	<code>pymdownx.critic</code>	✓ Built-in
Caret	<code>pymdownx.caret</code>	✓ Built-in
Tilde	<code>pymdownx.tilde</code>	✓ Built-in

Extensions to Remove

```
# REMOVE these from your markdown_extensions:
markdown_extensions:
- admonition                # Built-in
- pymdownx.details          # Built-in
- pymdownx.superfences      # Built-in
- pymdownx.highlight        # Built-in
- pymdownx.inlinehilite     # Built-in
- pymdownx.snippets         # Built-in
- pymdownx.tabbed           # Built-in
- pymdownx.arithmatex:      # Built-in
    generic: true
- tables                    # Built-in
- toc:                      # Built-in
    permalink: true
# Keep only truly custom extensions
```



Configuration-Free Markdown

DocsForge's Markdown processing is designed to "just work" with the features most documentation needs. The default setup covers ~90% of common use cases without any configuration.

Theme Migration

No Theme Installation Required

In MkDocs, you install the Material theme separately:

```
# MkDocs - required steps
pip install mkdocs-material
# Then in mkdocs.yml:
# theme:
#   name: material
```

In DocsForge, the Material theme is **built-in and always available**:

```
# docsforge.yml - NO theme section needed
# The theme is automatic
```

Theme Customization Migration

MkDocs Material theme options map to top-level DocsForge keys:

MkDocs Path	DocsForge Path
<code>theme.palette</code>	<code>palette</code>
<code>theme.features</code>	<code>features</code>
<code>theme.icon</code>	<code>icon</code>
<code>theme.logo</code>	<code>logo</code>
<code>theme.favicon</code>	<code>favicon</code>
<code>theme.font</code>	Remove — fonts are vendored
<code>theme.language</code>	<code>language</code>
<code>theme.custom_dir</code>	<code>custom_dir</code>

Example:

```
# MkDocs
# theme:
#   name: material
#   palette:
#     scheme: slate
#   features:
#     - navigation.tabs
#   logo: assets/logo.png

# DocsForge
theme:
  name: material
  palette:
    - scheme: slate
  features:
    - navigation.tabs
  logo: assets/logo.png
```

Asset Migration

Vendored Assets (Remove from Config)

DocsForge bundles common assets so you don't need to declare them:

Asset	MkDocs Approach	DocsForge Approach
KaTeX (math rendering)	<code>extra_javascript</code> + <code>extra_css</code>	Remove — built-in
Mermaid (diagrams)	<code>extra_javascript</code>	Remove — built-in
Material Icons	<code>extra_css</code> or theme font	Remove — built-in
Google Fonts	<code>theme.font</code>	Remove — vendored fonts
Pygments styles	<code>extra_css</code> or theme palette	Remove — automatic
JavaScript polyfills	<code>extra_javascript</code>	Remove — not needed

Remove These Declarations

REMOVE from mkdocs.yml — all are vendored in DocsForge

extra_javascript:

- `javascripts/katex.js` *# Remove*
- `javascripts/mermaid.js` *# Remove*
- `https://cdn.jsdelivr.net/npm/katex@0.16.9/dist/katex.min.js` *# Remove*
- `https://cdn.jsdelivr.net/npm/mermaid@10/dist/mermaid.min.js` *# Remove*

extra_css:

- `stylesheets/katex.css` *# Remove*
- `https://cdn.jsdelivr.net/npm/katex@0.16.9/dist/katex.min.css` *# Remove*
- `stylesheets/extra.css` *# Keep only if truly custom*

Custom Assets (Keep)

If you have truly custom CSS or JavaScript (not for vendored libraries), keep them:

docsforge.yml

extra_css:

- `stylesheets/custom-branding.css`
- `stylesheets/custom-layout.css`

extra_javascript:

- `javascripts/analytics.js`
- `javascripts/custom-interactions.js`



Don't Forget to Remove CDN Links

CDN links in `extra_javascript` and `extra_css` are the most common leftover from MkDocs migration. They add unnecessary network requests and can cause conflicts with vendored versions.

Common Issues During Migration

CSS Changes

Issue: Custom CSS that targeted MkDocs-specific class names doesn't work.

Solution: DocsForge uses similar but not identical CSS classes. Update your selectors:

```
/* MkDocs Material */
.md-header__inner { ... }
.md-nav__title { ... }

/* DocsForge */
.df-header__inner { ... }
.df-nav__title { ... }

/* Or use more stable selectors */
[data-md-component="header"] { ... }
[data-md-component="navigation"] { ... }
```



Inspect the DOM

Use browser dev tools to inspect the generated HTML and find the correct class names. The structure is similar to MkDocs Material but may use `df-` prefixed classes.

Plugin Differences

Issue: A plugin that worked in MkDocs behaves differently or is missing.

Solution:

1. Check if the feature is built-in (search, tags, minify, etc.)
2. Check the DocsForge plugin registry for alternatives
3. Remove the plugin from config if it's now built-in
4. For custom plugins, contact the author about DocsForge support

Path Issues

Issue: Links or image paths break after migration.

Solution: DocsForge uses the same path resolution as MkDocs for `docs/` content. Common fixes:

```
<!-- MkDocs - sometimes worked with relative paths -->
![[Alt]](../images/diagram.png)

<!-- DocsForge - always use absolute paths from docs root -->
![[Alt]](/images/diagram.png)
```

Math Rendering (KaTeX)

Issue: Math formulas don't render.

Solution: KaTeX is built-in. Remove all KaTeX-related scripts and styles from your config. Use standard syntax:

```
Inline:  $E = mc^2$ 

Block:

$$\sum_{i=1}^n x_i = x_1 + x_2 + \cdots + x_n$$

```

No configuration needed. No `extra_javascript`. No `extra_css`. It just works.

Diagram Rendering (Mermaid)

Issue: Mermaid diagrams don't render.

Solution: Mermaid is built-in. Remove Mermaid JS declarations from your config. Use fenced code blocks:

```
```mermaid
graph TD
 A[Start] --> B{Decision}
 B -->|Yes| C[Action 1]
 B -->|No| D[Action 2]
```
```

No `extra_javascript`. No `extra_css`. Built-in.

Search Index Differences

Issue: Search behaves differently (ranking, highlighting, etc.).

Solution: DocsForge uses a built-in search engine. It supports:

- Full-text search
- Stemming and tokenization
- Query highlighting
- Search suggestions

If you need custom search behavior, check the `search:` configuration section in `docsforge.yml`.

Build Output Differences

Issue: The built site has different file structure or URLs.

Solution: DocsForge generates the same URL structure as MkDocs (`/page/` for directories, `page.md` → `page/index.html`). If you see differences:

1. Check `use_directory_urls` setting (defaults to `true` in both)
2. Verify `site_url` is set correctly for canonical URLs
3. Check `nav` structure matches your intended hierarchy

Before/After Config Comparison

Complete Real-World Example

Here's a realistic `mkdocs.yml` from a project using Material theme with common plugins and extensions, and its DocsForge equivalent.

Before: `mkdocs.yml` (MkDocs)

```
site_name: Cloud Platform Docs
site_url: https://docs.cloudplatform.example.com
site_description: Documentation for the Cloud Platform
site_author: Platform Team

copyright: Copyright &copy; 2024 Platform Team

repo_url: https://github.com/cloudplatform/docs
repo_name: cloudplatform/docs
edit_uri: edit/main/docs/

theme:
  name: material
```

```

palette:
- media: "(prefers-color-scheme: light)"
  scheme: default
  primary: blue
  accent: blue
  toggle:
    icon: material/brightness-7
    name: Switch to dark mode
- media: "(prefers-color-scheme: dark)"
  scheme: slate
  primary: blue
  accent: blue
  toggle:
    icon: material/brightness-4
    name: Switch to light mode

features:
- navigation.tabs
- navigation.sections
- navigation.expand
- navigation.path
- navigation.top
- search.suggest
- search.highlight
- content.tabs.link
- content.code.copy
- content.action.edit

icon:
  repo: fontawesome/brands/github
logo: assets/logo.svg
favicon: assets/favicon.png
font:
  text: Roboto
  code: Roboto Mono

plugins:
- search:
    separator: '[\s\-,:!=\[\]\()"/]+\.\(?:!\d)|&[lg]t;|(\?!<\d)[:=\-\]|\$'
- minify:
    minify_html: true
- tags:
    tags_file: tags.md
- blog:
    blog_dir: blog
    blog_toc: true
- redirects:
    redirect_maps:
      old-page.md: new-page.md

markdown_extensions:
- admonition
- pymdownx.details
- pymdownx.superfences
- pymdownx.highlight:
    anchor_linenums: true
    line_spans: __span
    pygments_lang_class: true
- pymdownx.inlinehilite

```

```

- pymdownx.snippets:
  auto_append:
    - includes/abbreviations.md
- pymdownx.tabbed:
  alternate_style: true
- pymdownx.tasklist:
  custom_checkbox: true
- pymdownx.emoji:
  emoji_index: !!python/name:materialx.emoji.twemoji
  emoji_generator: !!python/name:materialx.emoji.to_svg
- pymdownx.arithmatex:
  generic: true
- def_list
- pymdownx.critic
- pymdownx.caret
- pymdownx.keys
- pymdownx.mark
- pymdownx.tilde
- tables
- toc:
  permalink: true
  title: On this page

extra_javascript:
- javascripts/katex.js
- https://cdnjs.cloudflare.com/ajax/libs/KaTeX/0.16.9/katex.min.js
- https://cdnjs.cloudflare.com/ajax/libs/KaTeX/0.16.9/contrib/auto-render.min.js

extra_css:
- https://cdnjs.cloudflare.com/ajax/libs/KaTeX/0.16.9/katex.min.css
- stylesheets/custom.css

extra:
  social:
    - icon: fontawesome/brands/github
      link: https://github.com/cloudplatform
    - icon: fontawesome/brands/twitter
      link: https://twitter.com/cloudplatform
  version:
    provider: mike
  analytics:
    provider: google
    property: G-XXXXXXXXXX

nav:
- Home: index.md
- Getting Started:
  - Installation: getting-started/installation.md
  - Configuration: getting-started/configuration.md
- Reference:
  - API: reference/api.md
  - CLI: reference/cli.md
- Blog: blog/

```

After: docsforge.yml (DocsForge)

```
site_name: Cloud Platform Docs
site_url: https://docs.cloudplatform.example.com
site_description: Documentation for the Cloud Platform
site_author: Platform Team
```

```
copyright: Copyright &copy; 2024 Platform Team
```

```
repo_url: https://github.com/cloudplatform/docs
repo_name: cloudplatform/docs
edit_uri: edit/main/docs/
```

```
# Theme is built-in – keep the "theme:" section
```

```
theme:
  name: material
  palette:
    - media: "(prefers-color-scheme: light)"
      scheme: default
      primary: blue
      accent: blue
      toggle:
        icon: material/brightness-7
        name: Switch to dark mode
    - media: "(prefers-color-scheme: dark)"
      scheme: slate
      primary: blue
      accent: blue
      toggle:
        icon: material/brightness-4
        name: Switch to light mode
```

```
features:
  - navigation.tabs
  - navigation.sections
  - navigation.expand
  - navigation.path
  - navigation.top
  - search.suggest
  - search.highlight
  - content.tabs.link
  - content.code.copy
  - content.action.edit
```

```
icon:
  repo: fontawesome/brands/github
logo: assets/logo.svg
favicon: assets/favicon.svg
```

```
# Font is vendored – no "font:" section needed
```

```
# Search, minify, tags, and blog are built-in – no "plugins:" entry needed
```

```
# Keep only non-built-in plugins:
```

```
# plugins:
```

```
#   - your-custom-plugin
```

```
# Extensions are built-in – remove all standard ones
```

```
# Keep only custom/non-standard extensions if any
```

```
# KaTeX is vendored – remove all KaTeX assets
```

```
extra_css:
```

```

- stylesheets/custom.css

extra:
  social:
    - icon: fontawesome/brands/github
      link: https://github.com/cloudplatform
    - icon: fontawesome/brands/twitter
      link: https://twitter.com/cloudplatform
  analytics:
    provider: google
    property: G-XXXXXXXXXX

nav:
- Home: index.md
- Getting Started:
  - Installation: getting-started/installation.md
  - Configuration: getting-started/configuration.md
- Reference:
  - API: reference/api.md
  - CLI: reference/cli.md
- Blog: blog/

```



What Changed?

- Kept the `theme: block` — Material is built-in
- Removed `theme.font:` — fonts are vendored
- Removed built-in plugins from `plugins:` (search, minify, tags, blog)
- Removed standard `markdown_extensions:` entries — they are built-in
- Removed `extra_javascript` and KaTeX `extra_css` — vendored
- Removed `redirects`, `version`, and other non-built-in plugins
- Kept `custom.css` — truly custom styling
- Kept `nav`, `extra`, `site_*` — same syntax

Step-by-Step Migration Checklist

Pre-Migration

- ☐ Commit all changes to version control
- ☐ Run `mkdocs build` to verify current site builds correctly
- ☐ Note any custom plugins or extensions that might not have equivalents
- ☐ List all `extra_javascript` and `extra_css` entries
- ☐ Identify which entries are for KaTeX, Mermaid, fonts, or other vendored assets

- ☐ Back up `mkdocs.yml` (it will be rewritten as `docsforge.yml`)

Migration

- ☐ Install DocsForge: `pip install docsforge`
- ☐ Rename `mkdocs.yml` to `docsforge.yml`
- ☐ Keep the `theme: block`; remove `theme.font:`
- ☐ Remove built-in plugins and extensions from explicit lists
- ☐ Remove vendored asset references (KaTeX, Mermaid, fonts, icons)
- ☐ Remove non-built-in plugins such as `redirects` and `version`
- ☐ Keep only truly custom `extra_css` and `extra_javascript` entries
- ☐ Verify `nav:` structure is unchanged
- ☐ Verify `extra:` variables are unchanged
- ☐ Verify `site_*` metadata keys are unchanged
- ☐ Check the updated `docsforge.yml` for correctness

Post-Migration

- ☐ Run `docsforge build` to test the build
- ☐ Compare built output with previous MkDocs build
- ☐ Check all pages render correctly
- ☐ Verify search works
- ☐ Verify dark/light mode toggle works
- ☐ Verify code highlighting works
- ☐ Verify admonitions render correctly
- ☐ Verify Mermaid diagrams render (if used)
- ☐ Verify math formulas render (if used)
- ☐ Verify custom CSS still applies correctly (update selectors if needed)
- ☐ Test all internal links
- ☐ Test all external links in `extra.social` or `nav`
- ☐ Run `docsforge serve` and do a visual review
- ☐ Commit the migrated configuration
- ☐ Update CI/CD pipelines to use `docsforge build` instead of `mkdocs build`
- ☐ Update documentation for contributors about the new build tool

- ☐ Remove `mkdocs.yml` from version control (after confirming migration works)
- ☐ Remove `requirements.txt` or `Pipfile` entries for MkDocs and plugins (if no longer needed for other projects)

Gradual Migration

You can run both MkDocs and DocsForge in parallel during transition. Keep `mkdocs.yml` as a backup while you validate the DocsForge build. Once satisfied, remove the MkDocs config and dependencies.

Troubleshooting

Build Failures

Error: `Unknown configuration key: theme.name`

Fix: Theme keys belong under the `theme:` block.

```
# Wrong
name: material
palette:
  - scheme: default

# Right
theme:
  name: material
  palette:
    - scheme: default
```

Error: `Plugin 'search' not found`

Fix: Do not declare built-in plugins under `plugins:`. Search is loaded automatically.

Error: `Extension 'pymdownx.highlight' not found`

Fix: Do not declare built-in extensions under `markdown_extensions:`. All common extensions are loaded automatically.

Visual Differences

Issue: Site looks different from MkDocs build.

Diagnosis:

1. Check if custom CSS selectors need updating (class names may differ)
 2. Verify no CDN assets are conflicting with vendored versions
 3. Check if `palette` or `features` settings match your MkDocs theme config
-

Issue: Icons missing or wrong.

Fix: DocsForge uses the same Material icon set. Check that icon names in `extra.social` or content use the correct format: `material/brightness-7` or `fontawesome/brands/github`.

Getting Help

If you encounter issues not covered in this guide:

1. Read the [DocsForge documentation](#)
 2. Search existing [GitHub issues](#)
 3. Open a new issue with:
 - Your original `mkdocs.yml`
 - Your current `docsforge.yml`
 - The error message or unexpected behavior
 - DocsForge version (`docsforge --version`)
-

Next Steps

After migration, explore DocsForge features that go beyond MkDocs:

- **Faster builds:** Incremental builds and hot reload
- **Built-in preview:** `docsforge serve` with live reload

Welcome to DocsForge! 🚀

🕒 Jun 17, 2026 🕒 Jun 06, 2026